

Field Notes on *Homo Scrollus*

A Naturalist's Reluctant Account of the Glorified Primates of the Late Anthropocene

by an Exasperated Anthropologist

I. Discovery

It is with great reluctance that I announce the discovery of a new subspecies: *Homo scrollus*, commonly known as the Modern Person. I had hoped, after three decades in the field studying bonobos and mandrills, that I might be granted retirement in peace. Instead, the grant committee insisted I turn my attention to “the most puzzling primate of all.” They were not wrong. They were, however, cruel.

My subjects were easy to locate — they never move — but extraordinarily difficult to interview. Most could not look up from their rectangles long enough to answer a single question. Those who did regarded me with the polite horror one reserves for a distant relative at a wedding.

II. Habitat

The Modern Person lives almost exclusively indoors, in modular boxes lit by the cold blue glow of rectangles. They have, through some collective delusion, convinced themselves that fresh air is “overrated” and that walking more than four hundred metres to a coffee shop constitutes “a journey.” They have invented a word for the act of moving their legs outdoors: *cardio*. They treat this word with the reverence medieval peasants reserved for penance.

When coaxed outside, they squint, complain about the sun, and immediately begin searching for somewhere with Wi-Fi and a power socket. The natural world, I am told, is “nice and everything” but lacks “amenities.” Trees, apparently, do not take reservations.

III. The Sacred Rectangle

At the centre of every Modern Person's life is a small glowing rectangle, approximately six inches diagonal, which they consult roughly one hundred and ten times per hour. This is not an exaggeration; I have counted. The rectangle tells them who is angry at them, what a stranger ate for breakfast, the weather in a city they will never visit, and — most importantly — whether they themselves are happy.

Should the rectangle's battery fall below seven per cent, the Modern Person exhibits symptoms not unlike a heroin addict denied their dose: tremors, profuse sweating, and a sudden, frantic religiosity. “Does anyone have a charger?” they whisper, eyes wild, in tones once reserved for the dying.

IV. Diet

The Modern Person subsists primarily on three food groups: avocado, oat milk, and anxiety. They are uniquely capable of being both overweight and malnourished simultaneously — a feat of biochemical ingenuity that deserves, if nothing else, a Nobel Prize. They will spend fourteen dollars on a smoothie containing kale, spirulina, and the tears of organic unicorns, then wash it down with three cigarettes and a panic attack about their cholesterol.

They are also obsessed with the precise naming of their dietary identity. Vegetarian, vegan, pescatarian, flexitarian, keto, paleo, “intuitive eater,” and — my personal favourite — “mostly plant-based but on weekends I’m a liability.” The bonobos, by contrast, simply eat what is in front of them and feel no need to announce it.

V. Communication

The Modern Person has evolved a sophisticated system of communication that consists almost entirely of abbreviations, acronyms, and small yellow faces. A typical exchange:

“Hey.”
“Hey.”
“lol”
“omg same”

This, to them, constitutes a meaningful interaction. They will later describe the conversation as “really catching up.” Eye contact, I should note, has been classified as endangered and is expected to be extinct by 2031. The yellow faces, meanwhile, have multiplied to express emotions the species has never actually felt: a face screaming, a face melting, a face with hearts for eyes. They deploy these in lieu of feeling the things themselves.

VI. Work

The Modern Person “works” by sitting at a slightly larger rectangle and moving a small plastic device around, occasionally pressing its buttons. This activity, they assure me, generates something called “value.” When pressed on what this value actually *is*, they become evasive and mutter about “synergies” and “deliverables.” I have, after months of study, concluded that approximately eighty per cent of modern work consists of scheduling meetings to discuss other meetings. The remaining twenty per cent is spent pretending to be busy on camera while actually shopping for shoes.

They are also — and I cannot stress this enough — exhausted. All of them. Always. A greeting of “How are you?” is invariably met with a long exhale and the word “tired.” When asked what they are tired *from*, they cannot say. They are tired in the way a phone is tired at six per cent: not from any particular exertion, but from the sheer labour of being switched on.

VII. Romance

Courtship among Modern Persons is conducted almost entirely through the rectangle. One “swipes” — a gesture resembling the dismissal of an unworthy servant — on photographs of

strangers. Should two strangers mutually swipe in approval, they will exchange fourteen to ninety messages, each more noncommittal than the last, before ghosting one another in silence. They will then install a dating application, delete it, reinstall it, and delete it again. This cycle repeats indefinitely and is known, bafflingly, as “putting yourself out there.”

Love itself has been reclassified as a “red flag” if displayed too early, a “green flag” if displayed at the correct latency, and a “trauma response” if displayed at all by anyone over forty. The bonobos, once more, are appalled.

VIII. Sleep

The Modern Person does not sleep so much as negotiate with sleep. They lie beneath their rectangles, scrolling through content that makes them feel either inadequate or furious, until approximately 2:47 a.m., at which point they set an alarm for 6:30 and vow to “do better tomorrow.” Tomorrow, of course, never comes. There is only today, and today is exhausting — see above.

IX. Self-Care

I am told the Modern Person engages in something called “self-care.” This appears to mean: buying scented candles, taking baths, and posting about both activities to an audience of strangers. Actual self-care — eating vegetables, going outside, speaking to another human without a screen between them — is considered “toxic positivity” or, worse, “cringe.”

They have therapists, which is good. They speak to them once a week, by video, from the same rectangle that caused the problems. This is known as “doing the work.”

X. Conclusion

I conclude, with the weariness of a man who has seen too much, that *Homo scrollus* is a species of extraordinary intelligence that has used said intelligence to engineer a life of maximum comfort and minimum contentment. They have conquered disease, hunger, and distance, only to be defeated by their own notifications. They have never been safer, richer, or more miserable. They have invented a device that holds all of human knowledge and use it chiefly to argue with strangers about films they have not seen.

I am returning to the bonobos. At least they have the decency to be honest about what they want.